

An Older Autistic Adult in Your Class / Group

For adult-education tutors, U3A/leisure-class leaders & community teachers — teaching an older autistic adult (roughly 60+).

The one idea

Autism, through **monotropism**, means an older learner's attention has always locked into a few deep, intense "tunnels." Many older autistic adults were never identified — a lifetime of "being a bit eccentric," strong interests and social fatigue may, in hindsight, be autism. In a calm, predictable, interest-led class they can be among your most engaged and knowledgeable learners. The adjustments that help (clarity, routine, less noise, more processing time) are gentle and help everyone — and they may be navigating hearing or vision changes that compound lifelong sensory differences.

What you may see — and what's really going on

You may see...	What's often happening
Deep knowledge of one topic; quiet elsewhere	Lifelong special interest — a strength to welcome
Needs the same seat, routine, materials each week	Predictability lowers the load — these are anchors, not "rigidity"
Slow to answer; asks you to repeat	Processing time + possible hearing loss — not confusion or incapacity
Drops out of noisy or unstructured sessions	Sensory/social overload, not lack of interest
Takes things literally; misses banter	Literal, single-channel communication

Try this

- **Keep the format predictable** — the same structure, room layout and materials; warn before any change.
- **Lower the sensory load** — reduce background music and echoes, offer good lighting and a quieter spot, account for hearing/vision loss.
- **Put key points and instructions in writing**, one thing at a time; allow ample processing time.
- **Welcome the special interest** — let them share expertise; it builds confidence and connection.
- **Offer low-pressure social options** — a quiet coffee after, a defined role, rather than forced mixing.

Avoid this

- Surprise changes, loud group exercises, or "think fast" demands.
- Assuming slowness or a different style means cognitive decline — assess, don't assume.
- Removing their familiar seat, materials or routine "for a change."

When to get more support

Be alert to **social isolation** (a major risk in this group) and gently signpost community and autism-led connection. If you notice a real change in skills or engagement, share it supportively with the learner and, where appropriate, their family — distinguishing lifelong autistic difference from genuine decline needs careful, autism-informed assessment.

If the learner is a woman

Older autistic women are an especially under-identified group, having masked for a lifetime. A history of “anxiety” or lifelong social/sensory difference is worth taking seriously.

About this guide

*AI-assisted, derived from this project's research drafts — the **Family guide** (Part 5), **Growing Up Monotropic** (Part 3) and the **Monotropism** brief, with the **Lifespan Practitioner & Health-Care guide** (Part 3.5). Uses identity-first language. **Informational — not a diagnostic tool**. Old-age evidence is thin; fit it to the individual.*

Key sources. Murray, Lesser & Lawson (2005); Murray, F. (2023); Dwyer (2025); Klein et al. (2024, aging & autism); BERA (2021, flow); OAR (aging on the spectrum). Full citations are in the source drafts.